

Goods (CPG) marketers budgeted an increasing amount of their advertising dollars towards online marketing. Thrifty Americans began trading in their scissors for downloadable printable coupons and online coupon codes.

The Internet is a logical place to deliver coupons to a web savvy culture. After all, everybody and their grandmother is on the web. For someone who had to be dragged, kicking and screaming, to sign up for a Facebook account, I now log on several times a day. The initial attraction wasn't that I could connect with family and friends—though that was an added bonus—the real attraction was the coupons.

“If you ‘Like’ Frito-Lay, you can download a \$1 coupon on Facebook,” someone would post on RefundCents.com, and a host of others would concur.

“Like” Frito-Lay? Download a coupon? I didn't even know what that meant. As a serious technophobe, I dug in my heels and resisted for months, despite the fact that my writing magazines reiterated the importance of authors joining the social network. I finally caved, joining Facebook in August of 2008 when the message boards were buzzing about particularly enticing coupons for as high as eight dollars or even sixteen dollars, coupons only available for users of Facebook. I was skeptical, but ready to join in the fun.

Only that fun turned out to be fraudulent.